

Elyria Catholic comeback effort falls short

Paul Hayse
The Chronicle-Telegram

MENTOR — Elyria Catholic gave a valiant effort, but an 18-point halftime deficit proved to be too large a hole to dig out off as the Panthers dropped a 78-63 North Coast League boys basketball game at Lake Catholic Friday night.

Chopping the difference on two occasions to five points in the third quarter, Elyria Catholic looked primed for its first victory after 10 straight defeats. However, the Panthers couldn't quite get over the hump.

The loss drops the Panthers to 1-12 overall, 1-8 in the North Coast League. Defeating EC for the second time this season, Lake

Catholic improved to 9-4 overall, 5-3 in the NCL.

Trailing 46-28 at halftime, Elyria Catholic sprang to life in the third quarter, outscoring the Cougars 23-12. The Panthers knocked home 11-of-20 shots while the Cougars were only 4-of-13.

Senior Pat Davis led the EC charge with 10 of his 14 points. Senior Kevin Fritz, along with juniors Matt Behne, Ryan Mack and Mike Groomes each had four in the frame.

For the evening, Fritz led EC with 15 points while Behne finished with 14.

Lake Catholic, however, got back on track in the final period to outscore Elyria Catholic, 20-12. The Panthers converted just

4-of-13 shots in the final period while Lake was 7-of-12.

"It was kind of a repeat of the first game that they beat us down the floor for easy buckets and we struggled (and) dug ourselves too deep a hole," said Mike Kearns, Elyria Catholic coach. "They're a very good defensively, very hard to defend."

Amen. The Cougars converted 22-of-40 shots from the field the first half while the Panthers struggled, making only 11-of-39. It was not a pretty sight for Kearns and Co.

"We just had too much to fight back from and we ran out of gas," said Kearns. "We had a chance to cut to three at least once, but we turned it over in the backcourt."

"We told the kids you're down

18 points to a team like this, and they can bury you," he said. "We told the kids at halftime the only thing we can ask you to do is play the next 16 minutes as hard as you can."

Kearns added, "Kids have to show their pride and I think their pride was hurt. I think they just decided to come out and have fun."

Elyria Catholic managed to keep it close after three periods, trailing by just seven, 58-51, but only came as close as six points the rest of the way.

"They're quicker than us and they made the plays down the stretch they had to," said Kearns.

Senior Ben Kelly was the main thorn in EC's side the first half, scoring 18 of his 20 points. Senior

Mike Hill had 14 for Lake, while junior Jason Battung and senior Bob Weiler added 13 and 11, respectively.

"It was almost too easy the first half," said Pat Lyons, Lake Catholic coach. "We were getting a lot of fast-break baskets. We came back to reality and lost our edge a little bit in the third quarter. I was just a little bit disappointed with our defense."

In the junior varsity game, Randy Deeks scored 18 points for Elyria Catholic (7-6, 3-5 NCL) in a losing cause, 60-42. Avenging a 62-50 setback, Mark Emanuele had 12 points for the Cougars (8-5, 5-3).

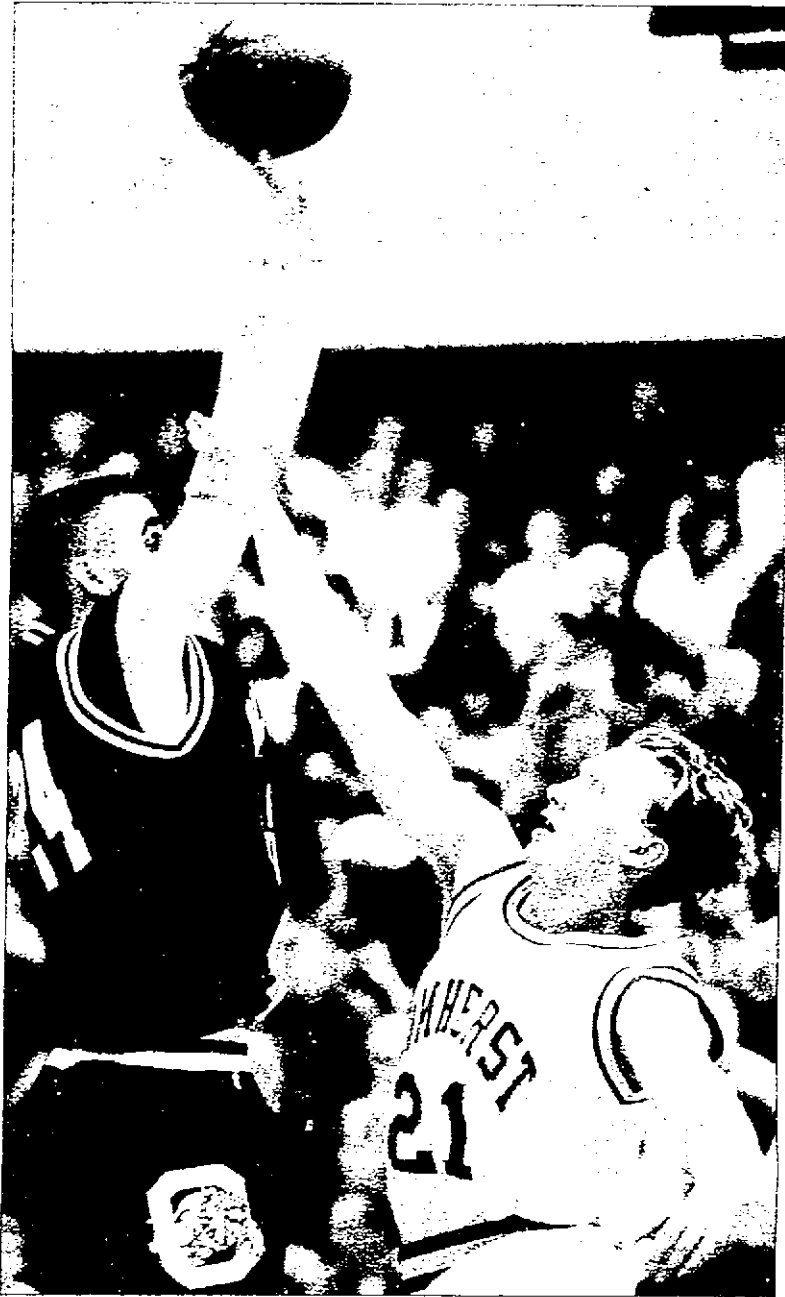
Elyria Catholic returns to action Tuesday when the Pan-

LAKE CATHOLIC (77)									
Players	G	F	FA	FT	F	P			
Eric Kelly	17	9	8	2	3	20			
Mike Hill	11	6	2	2	4	13			
Jason Battung	8	5	1	0	2	5			
Bob Weiler	10	4	3	2	0	11			
Keith Lash	9	2	6	3	1	7			
Frank Ray	9	2	0	0	1	6			
Joe Lasko	4	2	0	0	0	2			
Bill Espino	0	0	0	0	0	0			
Pat Manning	1	1	0	0	0	2			
TOTALS	62	33	18	9	13	78			

ELYRIA CATHOLIC (63)									
Players	G	F	FA	FT	F	P			
Kevin Fritz	14	8	3	0	2	15			
Mike Groomes	12	6	2	2	2	14			
Pat Davis	10	6	3	2	2	14			
Mike Groomes	8	4	0	0	1	8			
Ryan Mack	8	2	2	2	0	6			
Ed Zaborski	6	0	2	4	0	2			
Sam Marshall	3	0	4	0	0	2			
Eric Hartsness	2	1	0	0	0	2			
Vince Kueber	2	2	0	0	0	0			
TOTALS	72	26	13	10	13	63			

Score by Quarter					
Lake Catholic	24	12	12	20	78
Elyria Catholic	10	16	12	25	63

Three-Point Goals: Lake Catholic: 3-6 (Weiler 1-1, Kelly 1-1, Battung 1-2, Ray 1-2); Elyria Catholic: 1-17 (Fritz 1-5, Zaborski 0-1, Mack 0-2, Behne 0-2, Davis 0-7); Junior varsity: Lake Catholic 60-42.



TOM MAHL / CHRONICLE

THREE-POINT ATTEMPT: Olmsted Falls' Matt Tabar shoot over Amherst's Jeremy Dusho in Friday's Southwestern Conference showdown.

OLMSTED FALLS

From C1

lead. Amherst was 13-of-30 for 43 percent and 7-of-8 from the foul line.

But the second half was a defensive struggle. Falls took only 12 shots; Amherst 23.

The 3-pointers that Olmsted Falls' Matt Tabar hit early in the game dried up in the second half.

Tim Schaefer, with 20 points for the game, kept the Olmsted Falls offense going.

By the fourth quarter the only one doing anything for Amherst was Damasiewicz. He had all six of his team's points in the last period.

"We had one playing and four watching," Zvara said. "I told them in the huddle that we

needed all five."

Amherst, after trailing twice by 11 in the first half, had the lead late in the third quarter, once by 51-47. But the Bulldogs never rattled.

"Playing the games we've had helped us for this game," Donahue said. "We kept our composure here."

O. Falls						Amherst					
Schaefer	9	2	20	Damasiewicz	7	7	21				
Moore	0	2	2	Burke	1	0	2				
Newmeister	4	2	10	Rudi	1	0	2				
Matta	3	0	8	Dewick	4	0	9				
Tabar	4	7	14	White	4	1	11				
Stearns	0	0	3	Duino	4	0	10				
Sporck	1	0	4	Pena	3	0	9				
Hoggins	0	1	1	Lewis	0	0	0				
				Lugar	0	0	0				
				Azok	0	2	2				
Totals	21	17	56	Totals	21	10	57				

Points by Quarter

1	2	3	4	T
21	20	10	8	59
12	23	15	6	57

Three-point goals: Olmsted Falls: Tabar 4, Matt 2, Amherst: Dusho 2, White 2, Dewick 4, JV: Olmsted Falls 35-34 FT

NOTEBOOK

ELYRIA WEST'S dozen wins are the most for the school since it won 12 of 22 in 1990-91. That year, West was 8-4 at one point but never really got into the Lorain County Conference championship race. Avon and Brookside shared honors with 12-2 conference marks. In 1988-89, West was 16-5 overall and shared the LCC championship with Oberlin at 11-3. West won its first four conference games before losing to the Indians, 67-66. The Wolverines best record — the one this team wants — was 1977-78 when they won 18 times and lost only four. However, three of those came at the hands of cross-town Elyria Catholic, including a 64-63 heart-breaking district final that fans still talk about. In 83-84, West shared the now defunct Erie Coast Conference title with Lorain Catholic matching the school high for victories but losing five, including another tough, tough loss in district play, 65-63, to the Spartans.

THE VOICE at Elyria West's brand-spanking new sound system is hard-working Dave Knapp. Knapp has been president of Little League West, has umpired church softball games,

and generally has just been a real good guy.

WEST SHOT exactly 50% against Brookside Friday, hitting 33 of 66 floor shots. The Wolverines held Brookside to just 40 attempts. You won't lose many games with that kind of differential.

MARLON WADE, one of Mitch Giam's top substitutes, dressed for the Brookside game but did not play. Wade twisted his ankle in practice this week.

OLMSTED FALLS coach Pat Donahue said that the Bulldogs' beelied up schedule is by design. Falls played Barborton and Sandusky in the Streakball Classic and has played Elyria West and Strongsville. Saturday the Bulldogs faced Cleveland Benedictine.

"We're not looking at the tournaments at this point," Donahue said after Friday's game with Amherst. "But we've been to the regional three times and the games are at a level we haven't attained. If we do get there again, we'll see teams like we've been playing. Now the trick is to get there."

FORMER AMHERST coach Earl Haberfeld, now living in retirement in Wheeling, W.Va., was at the Amherst-Olmsted Falls game Friday.

STEVE BANSKED, Baldwin-Valley coach, was at the Amherst-Olmsted Falls game, looking at Amherst's 6-foot-7 senior Scott Roth.

Hitchens' shot keeps streak alive

Clearview nips Oberlin for fifth straight triumph

Robb Stolberg
The Chronicle-Telegram

OVERLIN — Chris Hitchens' dramatic steal and jump shot at the end kept Clearview's winning streak alive with a dramatic 74-72 Erie Shore Conference boys basketball victory at Oberlin Friday night.

The Clippers trailed by six points with only a minute left before pulling out the triumph, their fifth in a row and sixth in the last seven.

With 12 seconds left, Clearview's Robbie Collier tied the game at 72. Oberlin looked like it would be able to take the last shot of the game but Hitchens stole the ball after Oberlin's inbound and hit a jumper to sink the final basket and seal Clearview's win.

"That was a blur to me," said Clearview Coach John Szalay. "I just looked up and we had the ball again."

"That last 50 seconds every-

Clearview				Oberlin			
Alarcon	3	4	10	Bertina	8	2	18
Collier	3	3	9	Chambers	1	4	7
Gibbs	7	4	20	Gibbs	2	4	8
Johnson	3	0	8	Houghland	1	1	4
Hitchens	0	3	3	Lake	7	3	18
Hitchens	4	0	11	Thomas	5	2	15
Russell	5	3	13	Nelson	1	0	2
Totals	25	17	74	Totals	25	16	72

Points by Quarter

1	2	3	4	T
18	19	24	13	74
17	15	24	16	72

Three-point goals: Clearview: Chris Hitchens 3, Eric Gilbert 2, Derek Johnson 2; Oberlin: DeQuan Thomas 3, Jeff Chambers, Chris Houghland, Paten Lake.

Junior Varsity: Clearview 42-40.

thing went wrong that could possibly happen to us," said Oberlin Coach Joe Harris.

With a minute left, and Oberlin leading 71-65, Mario Gibbs missed two foul shots which would have increased the edge.

Oberlin turned the ball over twice in the next 30 seconds to allow Clearview within one after Derek Johnson's three point shot.

"We didn't take care of the ball going down the stretch," said Harris.

Oberlin opened up to a 13-8

lead with about 1:20 to go in the first quarter when suddenly the scoreboard power went out. And after the electrical problems, the Indians started to have some technical difficulties of their own.

Clearview finished the quarter with an 8-4 run. Andres Alarcon hit a turn-around jumper at the buzzer off a long inbound pass to get within one point of Oberlin.

After trading three-pointers early in the second period, Clearview began to pull away. The Clippers held the lead from 6:45 in the second until midway through the fourth quarter.

"It was a great team effort," said Szalay. "When they were out there they gave us everything they got."

Oberlin's passing was very sloppy, contributing to its 21 turnovers on the night.

Both teams hit plenty of outside shots, with the Clippers putting together 12 first-half points

off of threes. "Three-pointers is what kept them in the lead in the first half," said Harris.

Clearview stretched the 35-32 halftime lead to as many as nine points after Derek Johnson sank a three-pointer and a long jumper and Hitchens hit his third three-pointer of the night.

Oberlin pulled back to within two with a minute left in the third period but a technical foul charged to DeQuan Thomas gave the Clippers two freethrows and the ball.

The Indians finally evened the score at 63 as Antonio Barbra made two freethrows with 4:30 left in the game. Oberlin built momentum as it went ahead 71-65 as DeQuan Thomas dished in a no-look lay-up.

But then came the final dramatic rally by the Clippers.

The Indians sank to 7-5 (4-4) while Clearview improved to 5-3 in the LCC and 7-5 overall.

Avon holds off Wellington rally

John Ciarrone
The Chronicle-Telegram

WELLINGTON-Avon withstood a frantic fourth quarter comeback from Wellington by utilizing clutch free throw shooting down the stretch to finally put away the Dukes, 53-49 Friday night in a Lorain County Conference basketball game.

Poor execution, according to Avon coach Dave Kudela, allowed Wellington to get back into the game after Avon streaked out to a 21-2 first quarter lead. "We got the lead and then relaxed," commented Kudela. "We had opportunities to score, but the name of the game is putting the ball in the

Avon				Wellington			
Jones	5	2	12	Chappell	4	0	2
Guernsey	5	1	12	Wacker	1	0	2
Vega	4	5	14	Mullins	6	2	17
Harnden	1	0	5	Mills	1	2	5
Strawley	2	0	4	Wheeler	3	2	11
Benson	2	0	4	Martin	0	0	0
Cravford	2	0	2	Gallion	1	0	2
				Marti	1	3	5
Totals	19	13	53	Totals	17	10	49

Points by Quarter

1	2	3	4	T
21	7	13	12	53
2	15	14	18	49

Three-point goals: Avon: Vega, Guernsey; Wellington: Wheeler 3, Mills, Mullins; Jayvee: —

hole, and we just couldn't get it done."

After its first quarter surge, the Eagles were then grounded, hitting only eight of 22 shots in the second half and managed just three field goals in the fourth

quarter. Wellington didn't fare much better (11 of 25 for the second half) but it was enough to permit the Dukes to get to within a basket at 43-41 with 3 minutes left to play.

Avon was then able to convert eight of ten free throws in the final 2:00 to stave off the Dukes and go to 7-6 on the year (4-4 in LCC play).

"Down the stretch we did what we had to to win," said Kudela. "The last four games we've been shooting very poorly. Hopefully this will be our luck for the year."

For the game Avon wound up shooting 41 percent from the field (19 of 46) and wellington 32 percent (17 of 51).

Losing coach Jerry Camp was very pleased with the effort his team put forth, especially in light of the fact that two of his starters, including leading scorer Scott Booser, were dismissed from the team earlier this week due to disciplinary reasons.

The much-anticipated matchup between two of the conference's top gunners, Steve Vega and Booser, never materialized. But Camp liked what he saw of the team he did put on the floor.

"I'm proud of the kids," said Camp. "This was the best effort we've given all year. We worked hard at adjusting after that first quarter. I think we outplayed them for three quarters."



Tonight at 7:30 P.M.

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